

Document: Updated EU renewable energy rules to focus on simplification, not targets

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By Elena Giordano, Ben Munster · Sep 8, 2026, 4:46 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The EU is betting that cutting red tape rather than setting new legally binding goals will drive the next phase of its renewable energy push, according to a draft impact assessment for the post-2030 framework which makes no mention of a new 2040 renewables target.

The draft impact assessment for the next Renewable Energy Directive (RED), obtained by POLITICO, would overhaul the bloc's approach to renewables by cutting overlapping rules, easing implementation and shifting away from the sector-by-sector targets that have defined EU renewable policy for more than a decade.

The draft does not explicitly rule out introducing new binding targets beyond 2030. But the 70-page document makes no mention of any such target.

Instead, it says the "2040 climate and energy target architecture, including the EU's 2040 objective for renewable energy" would be assessed as part of a separate revision of the Governance Regulation — the overarching enforcement framework for the EU's energy and climate targets.

The Commission did not immediately respond when contacted by POLITICO. The document is a draft and could change.

The decision to forgo a binding target would be a significant shift from previous iterations of the RED. The first directive set mandatory national targets of 20 percent for 2020; RED II established a 32 percent EU renewable energy target for 2030; and RED III raised that to at least 42.5 percent, with an ambition to reach 45 percent.

The draft argues that the current framework has become too complicated, with overlapping requirements across the RED, energy efficiency, buildings, electricity and transport laws. Its preferred option would streamline rules on self-consumption, energy communities, regional cooperation, buildings, heating and cooling, and renewable-energy financing.

The document says these measures would be enough to ensure the EU meets its goal of generating 65-70 percent of energy from renewable sources by 2040. As of 2025, 26 percent of EU energy use came from renewable sources.

The Commission would also drop the current dedicated renewable heating-and-cooling trajectory after 2030, and replace it with technology-specific indicators for heat pumps, geothermal and solar thermal. The draft argues these would provide "technology-specific investment signals and dedicated visibility to

clean heat solutions.”

On permitting, the Commission also avoids introducing another overhaul. Instead, the draft says the executive would monitor national progress through common indicators, arguing that RED III and the 2026 Grids Package need time to take effect.

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